

an hour of gameplay and with shareware however, we are talking about a good solid chunk of gameplay. Quake for example offered the entire first episode in its shareware version for free, which is quite a bit considering Quake had four episodes of around eight levels each. You got one fourth of the game for free. Similarly, Doom, the predecessor to Quake—again by id—was released as shareware with a third of the game (1 of 3 episodes) available for free as shareware.

Now remember, Quake, Doom and Wolfenstein 3D (again one-third released as shareware) weren't exactly famous for their immersive storytelling, but as mechanically and technically sound games that were very fun to play. For a student who couldn't afford the game when it was released, playing through till the end wasn't as important as being able to play at all and have fun. This gave them a legal way to play the game and it has given id Software enough of a karma boost that even their less impressive games do well.

Free Games!

We have a very different model for free games today; and the kind of games you can get for free fall under some broad categories. These aren't exhaustive, and we don't want to be reductionist and say they in the end they will all boil down to these. Look on them as more of a general trend or common traits among free games.

Abandonware

Now here what we have is a concept that is legally dubious at best. Generally abandonware is considered to be software that is no longer being offered or sold by the people who created it. These creators often own the copyright and it is in fact illegal to download such software even though there is no way for you to get the software legally from the original creators. Sometimes due to the company going out of business, merging with another, or being bought out, the state of the copyright is unknown.

Technically they are neither free, nor paid, they are just not for sale—pretty much like the packet of biscuits I am eating right now. So why do we mention them at all? Because we feel this category is still linked—at least in people's minds—to freeware, or at least stuff you can get for free. Not mentioning it would be leaving a huge piece of culture out. In the mind of this author at least using abandonware isn't a moral issue, it's more of a legal one.